

Oneiric Image Seeds

Advanced 11+ creative writing pack: visual, strange, controlled description

This is the sharper companion to Classic Style Seeds. It is not a list of safe quotations. It is a workshop for making images: faces as weather, objects as biography, rooms with minds, child-made names, secrets as physical things and colours that behave badly.

Important rule: do not imitate a living author's voice. Study the craft move, then write a fresh sentence with your own subject, mood and detail.

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Modern Micro-Sparks

These are deliberately tiny fragments from modern writers whose prose feels image-rich and surprising. They are included as craft sparks only. The reusable material in the rest of the book is original.

Salman Rushdie - Midnight's Children

"handcuffed to history"

Craft move: A private life is chained to something huge and public.

Child-safe use: Attach a character to an event, family rule, city, rumour or deadline.

Source/context: <https://www.open.edu/openlearn/mod/resource/view.php?id=86832>

Salman Rushdie - Midnight's Children

"chutnification of history"

Craft move: An abstract idea is turned into a food process: history can be chopped, spiced, bottled.

Child-safe use: Turn memory, gossip, shame or pride into a physical process.

Source/context: <https://www.cambridge.org/core/books/salman-rushdie-in-context/salman-rushdie-and-history/25B56D82EA377846C020359CEFoB02DB>

Salman Rushdie - Midnight's Children

"swallow a world"

Craft move: Understanding a person becomes an impossible bodily action.

Child-safe use: Make knowing someone require eating, lifting, folding, unlocking or surviving something.

Source/context: <https://www.goodreads.com/work/quotes/1024288-midnight-s-children>

Arundhati Roy - The God of Small Things

"hot, brooding month"

Craft move: Time behaves like a living creature with a mood.

Child-safe use: Give a day, month or lesson an emotional temperature.

Source/context: <https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/153622-may-in-ayemenem-is-a-hot-brooding-month-the-days>

Arundhati Roy - The God of Small Things

"dustgreen trees"

Craft move: A colour is compressed with matter, making the image dirtier and more exact.

Child-safe use: Invent compound colours: chalkwhite, rainblue, bruisepurple, examgrey.

Source/context: <https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/153622-may-in-ayemenem-is-a-hot-brooding-month-the-days>

Arundhati Roy - The God of Small Things

"bluegreyblue eyes"

Craft move: Repeating colour creates a pulse, not a flat description.

Child-safe use: Repeat or fold colour when an object will not sit still.

Source/context: <https://journalhosting.ucalgary.ca/index.php/ariel/article/view/31389/25469>

Arundhati Roy - The God of Small Things

"Orangedrink Lemondrink Man"

Craft move: A child's label makes an adult vivid and uneasy through objects.

Child-safe use: Name a person by what a child notices first: smell, object, job, noise, habit.

Source/context: <https://www.sparknotes.com/lit/the-god-of-small-things/section2/>

Arundhati Roy - The God of Small Things

"fatly baffled in the sun"

Craft move: A surprising adverb makes a tiny death comic, physical and odd.

Child-safe use: Let an adverb do stranger work than slowly, loudly or sadly.

Source/context: <https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/153622-may-in-ayemenem-is-a-hot-brooding-month-the-days>

How To Use The Image Bank

Each seed gives a model, an engine, a frame and a task. The engine is the important part. Children should memorise a few favourite models, then practise changing the subject completely.

Good strange writing is still controlled writing. The image may be unexpected, but the reader should know exactly what is happening and what feeling the sentence creates.

Faces as weather

1. Late smile

Her smile arrived late, like sunlight finding a locked room.

Engine: Delay the expression, then compare it to light entering a place.

Frame: Her [expression] arrived late, like [light/weather] finding [closed place].

Try: Describe a shy child who wants to be friendly but cannot begin quickly.

2. Weather frown

His frown had weather in it: low cloud, no birds, the promise of rain.

Engine: Put a whole sky system inside one small facial movement.

Frame: His/her [expression] had weather in it: [sky detail], [absence], [threat].

Try: Describe a teacher before announcing bad news.

3. Eyebrow storm

A small storm lived between her eyebrows.

Engine: Make an emotion live in a precise facial address.

Frame: A small [weather event] lived between his/her [features].

Try: Show impatience without using impatient, annoyed or angry.

4. Unbuttoned calm

He wore calm like a coat that did not quite button.

Engine: Treat a mood as clothing, then reveal it is badly fitted.

Frame: He/she wore [emotion] like a [garment] that did not quite [fit-action].

Try: Describe someone pretending not to panic.

5. Steaming anger

Her anger did not shout; it steamed at the edges.

Engine: Give the emotion a quieter physical behaviour.

Frame: His/her [emotion] did not [obvious action]; it [subtle physical action].

Try: Describe fury controlled in public.

6. Bread kindness

His kindness had the temperature of bread just out of the oven.

Engine: Give a virtue temperature and texture.

Frame: His/her [quality] had the temperature of [warm/cold object].

Try: Describe a grandparent or neighbour in one sensory sentence.

7. Rained-on news

She looked freshly rained-on by bad news.

Engine: Let an event become weather on the body.

Frame: He/she looked freshly [weathered] by [event/feeling].

Try: Show disappointment after a result or rejection.

8. Changed map

The old man's face was a map after several countries had changed their names.

Engine: Make age visible as political geography.

Frame: The [person]'s face was a map after [large change].

Try: Describe an elderly face without saying wrinkled.

Eyes and looking

9. Ink drops

His eyes were two ink drops refusing to dry.

Engine: Use a tiny object that keeps its wetness and threat.

Frame: His/her eyes were two [dark objects] refusing to [settle/change].

Try: Describe someone silent but dangerous.

10. Arm's length

Her eyes kept the room at arm's length.

Engine: Give eyes social behaviour.

Frame: His/her eyes kept [person/place] at [distance].

Try: Describe a guarded newcomer.

11. Forbidden drawer

One glance from him was a key turning in a forbidden drawer.

Engine: Turn a look into a mechanical action inside secrecy.

Frame: One glance from [person] was a [tool] [action] in a [forbidden place].

Try: Describe a character who notices too much.

12. Moth-wing eyes

She had moth-wing eyes, powdery with secrets.

Engine: Use a fragile object and a tactile adjective.

Frame: He/she had [creature/object]-[part] eyes, [texture] with [abstract noun].

Try: Describe someone dreamy but unreliable.

13. Door-slipping gaze

His gaze slipped under doors before he did.

Engine: Make looking arrive before the body.

Frame: His/her gaze [entered/slipped/reached] before he/she did.

Try: Describe a nosy person entering a room.

14. Trouble seeds

Her pupils were tiny black seeds, ready to grow trouble.

Engine: Make a facial detail contain a future event.

Frame: His/her [feature] were tiny [objects], ready to grow [event].

Try: Describe a child about to misbehave.

15. Spent coins

His eyes were polished coins spent too often.

Engine: An object metaphor carries history and exhaustion.

Frame: His/her eyes were [objects] [used too often].

Try: Describe a charming person who has charmed too many people.

16. Water and moon

She watched with the stillness of water pretending not to know the moon.

Engine: Let stillness become sly rather than blank.

Frame: He/she watched with the stillness of [thing] pretending not to know [thing].

Try: Describe someone hiding recognition.

Bodies in motion

17. Posted through life

He entered folded, as if life had posted him through a narrow letterbox.

Engine: Use posture as evidence of a lifetime.

Frame: He/she entered [posture], as if life had [violent/comic action].

Try: Describe a timid child arriving late.

18. Offended bones

She sat as though each bone had been separately offended.

Engine: Make posture a committee of small injuries.

Frame: He/she sat as though each [body part] had been separately [emotion].

Try: Describe someone sulking theatrically.

19. Invisible furniture

His shoulders carried invisible furniture.

Engine: Show burden through one body part and an impossible object.

Frame: His/her [body part] carried invisible [heavy object].

Try: Describe guilt, responsibility or tiredness.

20. Hands land

Her hands fluttered, then landed, then forgot why they had come.

Engine: Let hands behave like nervous creatures.

Frame: His/her hands [movement], then [movement], then forgot [purpose].

Try: Describe someone trying to confess.

21. Spoon crossing

He walked with the caution of a spoon crossing a table edge.

Engine: Use a small domestic object to make movement precarious.

Frame: He/she moved with the caution of [object] crossing [edge/danger].

Try: Describe a child sneaking past a sleeping adult.

22. Elbows and warnings

She stood there, all elbows and weather warnings.

Engine: Fuse body shape with forecast language.

Frame: He/she stood there, all [body parts] and [warnings/signals].

Try: Describe awkwardness in a queue or classroom.

23. Laugh escapes

His laugh escaped first; the rest of him followed reluctantly.

Engine: Let one part of the person disobey the rest.

Frame: His/her [sound/expression] escaped first; the rest followed [adverb].

Try: Describe someone who cannot stay serious.

24. Question punctuation

She moved like a question that had not yet chosen its punctuation.

Engine: Make uncertainty grammatical and physical.

Frame: He/she moved like a [sentence type] that had not yet chosen [mark/end].

Try: Describe hesitation at a doorway.

Objects as biography

25. Lying tie

His tie looked as if it knew all his lies and had been strangled by them.

Engine: Make clothing witness the owner's character.

Frame: His/her [item] looked as if it knew all his/her [faults] and had been [punished] by them.

Try: Describe a pompous adult through one accessory.

26. Shiny apologies

Her shoes were too shiny for the day, little black apologies.

Engine: Let an object apologise for its owner.

Frame: His/her [objects] were too [quality] for the day, little [colour] [abstract nouns].

Try: Describe someone overdressed for an ordinary event.

27. Judging handbag

The handbag snapped shut with the authority of a judge.

Engine: Give an object legal or moral authority.

Frame: The [object] [action] with the authority of a [role].

Try: Describe a strict relative without naming her strictness.

28. Unposted excuses

His pockets sagged with unposted excuses.

Engine: Fill pockets with abstract things.

Frame: His/her pockets sagged with unposted [abstract plural].

Try: Describe a child who has forgotten homework.

29. Waiting-room coat

Her coat had the exhausted dignity of a curtain in a waiting room.

Engine: Give fabric social history.

Frame: His/her [garment] had the [emotion] dignity of [neglected object/place].

Try: Describe an old coat, bag or hat.

30. Smug watch

A gold watch winked on his wrist, smug as a secret.

Engine: Make jewellery complicit.

Frame: A [object] [small action] on [place], smug as a [secret/prize].

Try: Describe a rich or boastful character without saying rich.

31. Braver blazer

His school blazer seemed to belong to a braver boy.

Engine: Let clothing reveal a mismatch between role and self.

Frame: His/her [uniform item] seemed to belong to a [different quality] child.

Try: Describe first-day nerves.

32. Umbrella rehearsal

The umbrella dripped indoors, rehearsing bad luck.

Engine: Turn an object action into omen-making.

Frame: The [object] [ordinary action], rehearsing [future mood/event].

Try: Describe a house just before a quarrel.

Child-names and private labels

33. Sort-Of-Aunt

She was the Sort-Of-Aunt who brought biscuits and questions.

Engine: Use a child's category for an unclear adult role.

Frame: He/she was the Sort-Of-[role] who brought [object] and [pressure].

Try: Name a family friend through a child's eyes.

34. Whispering Adults

The room belonged to The Whispering Adults.

Engine: Capitalise a child's fear-name for a group.

Frame: The [place] belonged to The [adjective] [Adults/Teachers/Children].

Try: Describe a room where children are excluded.

35. Pocket Thunderstorm

He was a Pocket Thunderstorm in polished shoes.

Engine: Compress temperament into an impossible nickname.

Frame: He/she was a Pocket [weather/event] in [ordinary clothing].

Try: Describe a small child with huge emotions.

36. Maybe Door

They called it the Maybe Door, because grown-ups never used it.

Engine: Give an object a private mythic name.

Frame: They called it the [adverb/adjective] [object], because [reason].

Try: Invent a family name for a cupboard, gate or lane.

37. Chew-Chew Kingdom

The lunch hall became Chew-Chew Kingdom.

Engine: Let repetition make a comic kingdom.

Frame: The [ordinary place] became [sound-sound] Kingdom.

Try: Rename a noisy school place.

38. Chalk tests

Miss Vane was made of chalk dust, perfume and sudden tests.

Engine: Build a person from materials and habits.

Frame: [Name] was made of [substance], [smell] and [habit/event].

Try: Describe a teacher with three concrete ingredients.

39. Big Don't-Ask

Grandfather's silence was called The Big Don't-Ask.

Engine: Turn a family taboo into a named object.

Frame: [Person]'s silence was called The Big [command].

Try: Describe a family secret without revealing it.

40. Yesterday Face

The new boy had a Yesterday Face.

Engine: Give a face a time-label instead of adjectives.

Frame: The [person] had a [time] Face.

Try: Describe a character who seems haunted or homesick.

Places with minds

41. Corridor yawn

The corridor stretched like a yawn nobody wanted to finish.

Engine: Make architecture behave like a tired body.

Frame: The [place] stretched like a [body action] nobody wanted to [finish/notice].

Try: Describe a dull school corridor.

42. Trapped Mondays

The classroom smelled of pencil shavings and trapped Mondays.

Engine: Mix one real smell with one impossible time-smell.

Frame: The [place] smelled of [real smell] and trapped [day/emotion].

Try: Describe an exam room before the test begins.

43. Worry soup

The kitchen was a warm machine for turning worry into soup.

Engine: Let a room process emotion into food.

Frame: The [room] was a [temperature] machine for turning [emotion] into [object/food].

Try: Describe a family kitchen during bad news.

44. Green opinions

The garden had gone feral with green opinions.

Engine: Make plants sound argumentative.

Frame: The [natural place] had gone [wild adjective] with [colour] opinions.

Try: Describe an overgrown place.

45. Station cough

The station swallowed people and coughed up echoes.

Engine: Give a public place a body with rude actions.

Frame: The [place] swallowed [people/things] and coughed up [sound/remains].

Try: Describe a busy station, mall or school gate.

46. Bedroom witness

The bedroom waited like a witness.

Engine: Turn a room into someone who has seen too much.

Frame: The [room] waited like a [silent role].

Try: Describe a room after an argument.

47. Too many corners

The house had too many corners for one family.

Engine: Use architecture as emotional pressure.

Frame: The [place] had too many [parts] for one [group/person].

Try: Describe a house full of secrets.

48. Rain pretence

The street glittered after rain, pretending nothing had happened.

Engine: Let the setting lie politely.

Frame: The [place] [beautiful action] after [event], pretending nothing had happened.

Try: Describe a street after an accident or quarrel.

Memory and secrets

49. Sugar memory

Memory sat in the corner, licking sugar from its fingers.

Engine: Personify memory as badly behaved and sensory.

Frame: [Abstract noun] sat in the corner, [physical action].

Try: Describe a pleasant memory that will not leave.

50. Secret handles

The secret grew handles; everyone had carried it.

Engine: Make the secret portable and shared.

Frame: The [secret/rumour] grew [parts]; everyone had [handled action] it.

Try: Describe a rumour moving through school.

51. Yesterday leak

Yesterday leaked under the door.

Engine: Let time enter a room like water.

Frame: [Past time] leaked under the [opening].

Try: Describe an old mistake returning.

52. Folded family story

The family story had been folded so often it had lost its edges.

Engine: Make repeated telling wear out a truth.

Frame: The [story/lie/excuse] had been [handled] so often it had lost [part].

Try: Describe a family legend that may not be true.

53. Lamp guilt

Guilt kept a small lamp burning behind his ribs.

Engine: Place an abstract feeling inside the body as an object.

Frame: [Emotion] kept a small [object] [action] behind his/her [body part].

Try: Describe someone hiding remorse.

54. Furniture truth

The truth was not hidden; it was dressed as furniture.

Engine: Make concealment ordinary and domestic.

Frame: The [truth/problem] was not hidden; it was dressed as [ordinary object].

Try: Describe something everyone ignores.

55. Brittle promise

Her promise turned brittle in the mouth.

Engine: Make speech change texture as it is spoken.

Frame: His/her [spoken thing] turned [texture] in the mouth.

Try: Describe a lie as it is being told.

56. Thumbprint history

History pressed its thumbprint into his forehead.

Engine: Let history touch the body like an official mark.

Frame: [Big force] pressed its [mark] into his/her [body part].

Try: Describe a child shaped by family expectations.

Colour and strange senses

57. Yellow argument

The afternoon was yellow with argument.

Engine: Give an argument a colour wash over time.

Frame: The [time/place] was [colour] with [emotion/event].

Try: Describe a family meal before a row.

58. Green silence

A greenish silence collected in the sink.

Engine: Make silence visible and place it somewhere domestic.

Frame: A [colour-ish] silence collected in the [object/place].

Try: Describe a quiet kitchen after bad news.

59. Metal lilies

The room tasted of metal and lilies.

Engine: Use taste for atmosphere, not food.

Frame: The [place] tasted of [hard thing] and [soft/fragrant thing].

Try: Describe a hospital, chapel or formal room.

60. Purple bruises

Her voice left purple bruises in the air.

Engine: Make sound leave visible damage.

Frame: His/her voice left [colour] [marks] in the air.

Try: Describe a cruel remark.

61. Black beads

The piano notes fell like black beads down a staircase.

Engine: Turn sound into small falling objects.

Frame: The [sounds] fell like [colour objects] down [place].

Try: Describe music from another room.

62. Old pear sky

The sky had the grey sweetness of an old pear.

Engine: Combine colour with taste and age.

Frame: The [natural thing] had the [colour] [taste] of [aged object].

Try: Describe unpleasant weather precisely.

63. Honey lamps

The lamps made pools of honey on the floor.

Engine: Make light sticky and edible.

Frame: The [lights] made pools of [substance] on the [surface].

Try: Describe a warm room at night.

64. Blue fingerprints

Dusk put blue fingerprints on the windows.

Engine: Let time leave coloured evidence.

Frame: [Time of day] put [colour] fingerprints on the [surface].

Try: Describe evening arriving in a room.

Practice Lab

Character portrait - do not say the trait

For each dull idea, write one strange image sentence. Ban the obvious trait word.

1. A greedy person enters a room.

2. A nervous child waits outside the headteacher's office.

3. A proud parent watches a school performance.

4. A lonely new pupil eats lunch alone.

Eyes without eye colour

Do not use blue, brown, green, pretty, bright, dark or sparkling.

1. Make the eyes reveal suspicion.

2. Make the eyes reveal kindness.

3. Make the eyes reveal a secret.

4. Make the eyes reveal boredom.

Child-naming drill

Use capital letters only when the name feels invented by a child.

1. Rename a frightening adult.

2. Rename a place children are not allowed to enter.

3. Rename an embarrassing family rule.

4. Rename a noisy school event.

Rooms with minds

Make the place behave, wait, lie, digest, swallow, remember or accuse.

1. A kitchen during an argument.

2. A classroom before an exam.

3. A bedroom after a secret has been discovered.

4. A corridor at night.

Secrets made physical

Give the abstract thing weight, smell, handles, teeth, heat or a hiding place.

1. A rumour passes through school.

2. A lie is told at dinner.

3. A memory returns during a lesson.

4. A promise becomes impossible to keep.

Colour invention

Try compounds like examgrey, milkblue, dustgreen, bruise gold. Then explain the choice.

1. Invent a colour compound for panic.

2. Invent a colour compound for boredom.

3. Invent a colour compound for jealousy.

4. Invent a colour compound for relief.

Dream logic, controlled

Keep grammar clear. The image may be strange; the sentence must not be muddy.

1. A staircase refuses to end.

2. A door seems to recognise someone.

3. A clock behaves like a tired animal.

4. A family photograph appears to know too much.

Upgrade a flat sentence

Write three versions of each: weather, object, and body-based.

1. He was angry.

2. She was embarrassed.

3. The room was quiet.

4. The man looked old.

Mini-paragraph challenge

Use at least three image engines, but keep the meaning easy to follow.

1. Describe a new teacher in 80 words.

2. Describe a family dinner just before bad news arrives in 80 words.

3. Describe a child entering a strange house in 80 words.

Final synthesis

Use one child-name, one place with a mind, one colour invention and one secret made physical.

1. Write the opening of a story called The Maybe Door.

2. Write the opening of a story called The Boy With a Yesterday Face.

3. Write the opening of a story called The House With Too Many Corners.

Teacher Marking Grid

Skill	What to look for
Precision	The image is exact, not decorative fog.
Originality	The sentence avoids the first obvious comparison.
Control	The reader can still understand the literal action.
Transfer	The child can explain the frame and create a new version.
Vocabulary	Strong nouns and verbs carry the image; adjectives do not do all the work.

Final warning for the children: weirdness is not enough. A strange sentence must still reveal character, place, emotion or tension. If it only sounds clever, cut it.